

First resort: On Donald Trump's mass deportation drive

Donald Trump should use **diplomacy**, not **coercion**, in deportation of **migrants**

Donald Trump's mass deportation drive hit its first hurdle on Sunday (January 26, 2025) when Colombian President Gustavo Petro refused permission to two United States military planes carrying migrants to land. A **furious** Mr. Trump announced that the U.S. would **impose** a 25% **tariff** on all Colombian goods, which would be raised to 50%. The U.S. also threatened to impose banking and financial **sanctions** and issue travel bans on Colombian officials and **associates**. **Mr. Petro**, a **former guerrilla**, **responded in kind** by saying Colombia would also impose tariffs up to 50% on American goods and refused to "shake hands with white **slaveholders**". But Bogota, under pressure, **eventually** accepted to take back the migrants "with dignity and respect". A trade war would have been bad news for both countries whose **bilateral** trade stood at \$53.5 billion in 2022, with a \$4 billion **surplus** for the U.S. High tariffs would have been a **body blow** for Colombia, as the U.S. is its largest trading partner. With tariffs and financial and political sanctions, America could **cripple** Colombia's economy and **destabilise** its polity at a time when its fight with guerrillas is **escalating** after a **lull**. Unsurprisingly, Mr. Petro **backtracked** and agreed to accept what the White House said was "all its terms".

Colombia and other South American countries have been taking **undocumented** migrants back from the U.S. in recent years. In January, there were 90 deportation flights from the U.S. to its southern neighbours, eight of which landed in Colombia. But what turned a regular exercise into a controversy was the handling of the deportation by the Trump administration — the use of mostly military planes, which **angered** the Colombians. Mr. Petro also raised concerns about the way migrants were treated by the U.S. Earlier, Brazil had also raised complaints of "**degrading** treatment" of its **deported** citizens. They were **handcuffed**, and some of them were not given water or allowed to use the washroom during the flight, according to Brazilian officials. But Mr. Trump does not seem to care. He wanted to make an example of Colombia so that other neighbours will not challenge his handling of the mass deportation. He may have forced Colombia to backtrack for now, using America's **economic muscle**, but this kind of coercion could **backfire in the long run** in a region where America has always tried to maintain its **geopolitical hegemony**. And the **inhumane conditions** in which hundreds of migrants are being deported everyday **are** a **blot** on America's **tall claims** of protecting human rights. A better way of handling this crisis is through diplomacy. Instead of imposing his **will** on other countries through threats of tariffs and sanctions, Mr. Trump could use the diplomatic channel, **seek consensus** and then implement his policy in a much more **cordial** way. But for Mr. Trump, **alas**, coercion is the first resort.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'. **[Practice Exercise]**
- **Cripple** (verb) – to seriously damage or harm somebody/something (किसी को) गंभीर रूप से क्षतिग्रस्त कर देना

Vocabulary

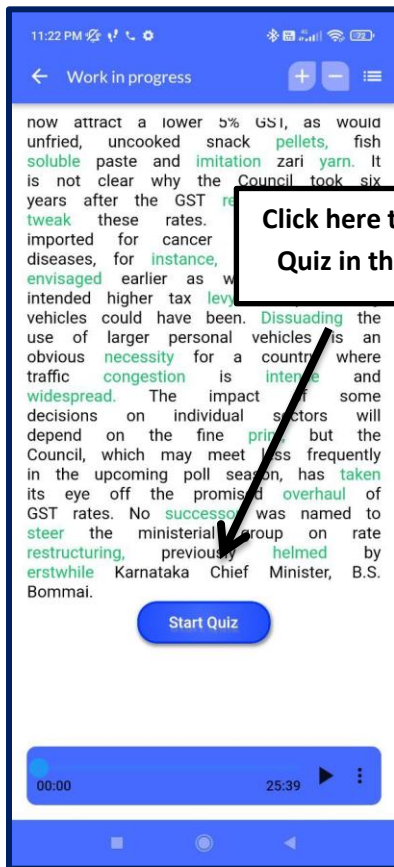
1. **First resort** (phrase) – immediate choice, first course of action, primary option, default approach, initial method पहला उपाय
2. **Deportation** (noun) – expulsion, removal, banishment, extradition, forced return देश निकाला
3. **Drive** (noun) – campaign, initiative, push, effort, movement अभियान
4. **Diplomacy** (noun) – negotiation, tact, statesmanship, foreign relations, finesse कूटनीति
5. **Coercion** (noun) – force, compulsion, pressure, intimidation, duress जबरदस्ती
6. **Migrant** (noun) – immigrant, emigrant, traveler, wanderer, refugee प्रवासी
7. **Furious** (adjective) – angry, enraged, irate, livid, wrathful बहुत क्रोधित
8. **Impose** (verb) – levy, enforce, place, inflict, promulgate थोपना
9. **Tariff** (noun) – duty, tax, levy, customs charge, import fee शुल्क
10. **Sanction** (noun) – penalty, punishment, restriction, measure, ban प्रतिबंध
11. **Associate** (noun) – partner, ally, colleague, collaborator, comrade सहयोगी / साथी
12. **Former** (adjective) – previous, earlier, ex-, one-time, erstwhile पूर्व
13. **Guerrilla** (noun) – a member of a small military group who are not part of an official army and who make surprise attacks on the enemy
14. **In kind** (phrase) – in the same manner, similarly, in the same way, reciprocally, likewise उसी प्रकार
15. **Slaveholder** (noun) – slave owner, enslaver, master, keeper of slaves, exploiter दास मालिक
16. **Eventually** (adverb) – finally, ultimately, in the end, at last, after some time अंततः
17. **Bilateral** (adjective) – two-sided, mutual, reciprocal, joint, involving two parties द्विपक्षीय
18. **Surplus** (noun) – excess, extra amount, remainder, overage, additional supply अधिशेष
19. **Body blow** (phrase) – serious setback, heavy blow, severe setback, damaging strike, major shock बहुत बड़ी क्षति / बड़ा झटका
20. **Destabilise** (verb) – unsettle, weaken, undermine, disrupt, upset अस्थिर करना
21. **Escalate** (verb) – intensify, heighten, increase, amplify, magnify बढ़ाना / तेज करना

22. **Lull** (noun) – pause, respite, break, quiet period, temporary calm शांत काल / विराम
23. **Backtrack** (verb) – reverse course, retract, go back on, reconsider, withdraw पीछे हटना
24. **Undocumented** (adjective) – unrecorded, without official papers, unauthorized, illegal, unverified बिना दस्तावेज़ / अवैध
25. **Anger** (verb) – infuriate, enrage, incense, provoke, irritate क्रोधित करना
26. **Degrading** (adjective) – humiliating, demeaning, shameful, lowering, debasing अपमानजनक
27. **Deported** (adjective) – expelled, ousted, removed, banished, sent away निर्वासित
28. **Handcuff** (verb) – restrain, shackle, fetter, manacle, chain हथकड़ी लगाना
29. **Economic muscle** (noun) – financial power, economic strength, monetary influence, fiscal dominance, economic might आर्थिक शक्ति
30. **Backfire** (verb) – boomerang, rebound negatively, result counterproductively, fail, blow up in one's face उल्टा पड़ना
31. **In the long run** (phrase) – eventually, over time, ultimately, in the future, after a while लंबी अवधि में / अंततः
32. **Geopolitical** (adjective) – related to international relations, global politics, strategic geography, geostrategic, political geography भू-राजनीतिक
33. **Hegemony** (noun) – dominance, leadership, supremacy, control, authority प्रभुत्व / वर्चस्व
34. **Inhumane** (adjective) – cruel, brutal, merciless, ruthless, barbaric अमानवीय
35. **Blot** (noun) – stain, blemish, mark, disgrace, taint कलंक
36. **Tall claims** (phrase) – exaggerated statements, grand assertions, boastful declarations, big talk, lofty promises ऊँचे दावे
37. **Will** (noun) – volition, determination, choice, desire, wish इच्छा
38. **Seek** (verb) – look for, strive for, pursue, aim for, search तलाशना
39. **Consensus** (noun) – agreement, accord, unity, harmony, general consent सर्वसम्मति
40. **Cordial** (adjective) – friendly, warm, amicable, affable, genial सौहार्दपूर्ण / मैत्रीपूर्ण
41. **Alas** (exclamation) – unfortunately, sadly, regrettably, sorrowfully, oh dear अफ़सोस / हाय

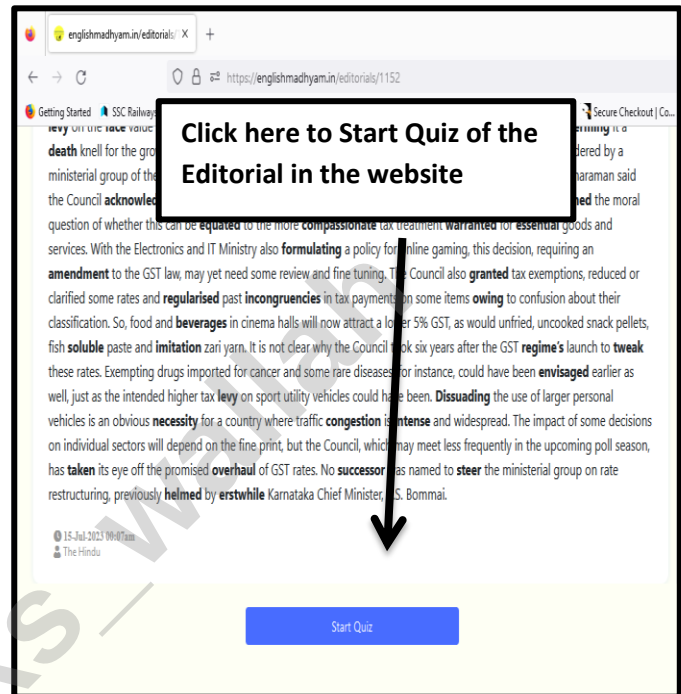
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Mass Deportation Controversy:** Donald Trump's mass deportation drive faced a major hurdle when Colombian President Gustavo Petro denied landing permission to U.S. military planes carrying migrants.
2. **U.S. Retaliation:** Trump responded by announcing a 25% tariff on Colombian goods, threatening to increase it to 50%, alongside potential banking and financial sanctions and travel bans.
3. **Colombian Response:** Petro countered by announcing similar tariffs on U.S. goods and condemned Trump's actions, referring to them as oppressive.
4. **Economic Stakes:** A trade war between the U.S. and Colombia would have hurt both economies, as bilateral trade totaled \$53.5 billion in 2022, with a U.S. surplus of \$4 billion.
5. **Colombian Concession:** Under economic and political pressure, Colombia eventually agreed to take back migrants while demanding "dignity and respect" in the process.
6. **Role of Economic Muscle:** The editorial highlights how the U.S. used its economic dominance to coerce Colombia into compliance, risking long-term regional instability.
7. **Regular Deportation Practices:** Colombia and other South American countries have been receiving deported migrants from the U.S., with 90 flights recorded in January, eight of which landed in Colombia.
8. **Controversial Deportation Methods:** The Trump administration's use of military planes for deportations angered Colombians, turning a routine practice into a diplomatic flashpoint.
9. **Migrant Treatment Concerns:** Both Colombia and Brazil raised concerns about the inhumane treatment of deported migrants, including handcuffing, lack of water, and restricted access to washrooms.
10. **Brazil's Complaints:** Brazilian officials described the treatment of their deported citizens as "degrading," further amplifying regional discontent.
11. **Trump's Intent:** Trump's strategy aimed to make an example of Colombia, discouraging other countries from opposing his mass deportation policies.
12. **Potential Backfire:** The editorial warns that Trump's coercive approach might lead to long-term resentment in South America, where the U.S. has historically sought geopolitical dominance.
13. **Human Rights Violation:** The editorial critiques the inhumane deportation process as tarnishing America's reputation as a defender of human rights.
14. **Diplomatic Alternative:** A more effective approach, the editorial suggests, would involve diplomacy, consensus-building, and mutual respect between the U.S. and its neighbors.
15. **Trump's Approach Criticized:** The piece concludes that Trump's preference for coercion over diplomacy undermines the possibility of sustainable solutions and damages America's global standing.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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